



AMERICAN DREAMERS: McCain and his wife Cindy (far left), Obama with his wife Michelle in New York



Today, the QUESTION is, who of the two is better suited to take charge of a SUPERPOWER wracked by economic and military ANXIETIES?

McCain remains unrepentant. In his defence of his choice, she is an outsider only for the Georgetown cocktail circuit. Another elitist conspiracy.

Elitism in Washington today is spelt Obama, and it seems nobody is ashamed of being an elitist. He has already become a statesman (maybe a bit prematurely) and statement. He is the original Teflon candidate. He has overcome his erstwhile mentor and spiritual guru Jeremy "God Damn America" Wright. He, more or less, remains unaffected by his old association with "domestic terrorist" Bill Ayers. If elected, he will be the post-racial salvation figure of America. Born to a black Kenyan father and white Kansas mother, he avoided racial entrapment with supreme skill and tact. He is not the angry black American wallowing in victimhood. He has become a unifying force, and a generational rage. Still, the triumph of the Obama text is made possible by the Bush context. Increasingly, it looks like McCain is incidental. The candidate Obama is pitted against is the one who is not in the fray to take up the challenge. Says Thomas Mann of Brookings Institution: "A discredited presidency, an unpopular war, a damaged American brand and a desperate urge for change set the stage for the Obama phenomenon." (And what about the

record breaking fund-raising by Obama—\$150 million in the month of September alone?). He has no doubt about an Obama victory—"350 electoral votes and a 6 per cent lead in popular vote". And a filibuster-proof Democratic majority in the Congress. Two-hundred-and-seventy electoral college votes are required to win the elections. Al Gore won the popular vote and lost the electoral college vote—and hence the election. If he is proved wrong on November 4, Mann, a political scientist, says he will change his profession and become a brain surgeon. That's the extent of faith in the Obama brand, which continues to be endorsed by such worthies as Colin Powell.

This election is all about faith—or the loss of it. There comes a moment in the life of a nation when a regime change is a revolutionary prologue. America had so many such moments. The last one was the Reagan revolution. Is another ambitious American project about to rise on the debris of neo-conservatism? Or, is the audacity of one black man with an exotic back story going to be the destiny of the most powerful nation on earth? This election is Obama's—to win or lose. The ageing pilot can only be an incidental beneficiary or loser in this election in which history is the invisible campaigner. ■